

Elderly Changes

Prepared by

Dr/Amany Mohamed Saad

Professor of Community Health Nursing

Outlines:-

- 1. Introduction.**
- 2. Definitions that describe the Gerontological Nursing practice .**
- 3. Social view of older adults.**
- 4. Classification of elderly people.**
- 5. Normal age- related changes:-**
 - 1) Physical Change.**
 - 2) Psychosocial Changes.**

Introduction:-

Old age does not come suddenly it has long process.

Healthy life styles established during childhood

,adolescence and youth age and continued in later life are

helpful in delaying the ageing process and maintain quality

of life.

In Egypt, the life expectancy has shown a significant increase recently, in the number of elderly. The number of them reached nearly 4 million in 2006, represented 7.3% of total population in 2011 and expected to rise in the ratio to 11.6% in 2030.

Definitions that describe the Gerontological Nursing practice :-

- **Gerontology:** - Is the study of physical , psychological , social and spiritual aspects of the old age person.
- **Geriatrics:** - Is the branch of general medicine that related to study of the disease and illness of the older adults.
- **Gerontological Nursing:-** Is the branch of nursing concerned with assessment of the health needs of older adults, planning and implementing health care to meet these needs and evaluating the effectiveness of such care.

- **Elderly:** - Is person who 60 years or more.
- **Life expectancy:-** Is the average number of years that a person can be expected to live.

Social view of older adults:-

The social position of old people is determined by culture.

Certain roles are assigned to the older person.

- **Ageism** :- Unfavorable attitude toward the elderly, is a negative phenomenon which results in viewing old people in a prejudiced manner simply because they are old.
- **Stereotypes**:- Simplified and often untrue beliefs, reinforce society's negative image of the older person.

Classification of elderly people: - Elderly population classified as follows:

- 1- People between 60-74 years are categorized as "**young old**".
- 2- People between 75-84 years are categorized as "**old-old**".
- 3- People above the age of 85 years old are classified as "**very old**".
- 4- A fourth group of persons, 100 years old and older (**centenarians**) is growing rapidly. The majority of these centenarians will be women.

Normal age- related changes:-

1) Physical Changes:-

Most physical changes that occur with aging are gradual and take place over a long period of time. In addition, the rate and degree of change varies among individuals. Factors such as disease can increase the speed and degree of the changes. Lifestyle, nutrition, economic status, and social environment can also have effects. If an individual can recognize the changes as a normal part of aging, the individual can usually learn to adapt & cope with change.

1- Integumentary System Changes:-

- **Skin** becomes less elastic & dry and fragile
- Production of new skin cells decreases.
- Oil and Sweat glands become less active.
- Circulation decreases.
- Itching is common.
- Dark yellow or brown colored spots appear.
- Fatty tissue layer of skin diminishes.
- Lines and wrinkles appear.

- **Hair** losses color and become gray in color.
- Hair loss occurs.
- **Nails** become thick, and brittle.
- Increased sensitivity to temperature.

Care of the Skin

- Use mild soap.
- Use oils or lanolin lotion.
- Bath or shower once or twice a week.
- Brush hair daily.
- Use shampoo as needed for cleanliness and comfort.
- Care for sore and injuries immediately.
- Use socks, sweaters, and layers of clothing will help alleviate the feeling of coldness.

2- Cardiovascular System changes:-

- Heart size does not change with age.
- Decrease function of the system.
- Decrease cardiac output .
- Decrease elasticity of heart muscle and arteries.
- Decrease heart rate.
- Increase blood Pressure, and atherosclerosis may occur.

Circulatory System Care

- **With circulatory changes:-**
 - Avoid over hard exercise or over exertion.
 - Periods of rest.
 - Moderate exercise, according to individual's tolerance.
- **High Blood Pressure :-**
 - Diet low in salt.
 - Decrease fat intake.
 - Exercise as recommended by physician.

3- Respiratory Changes:-

- Respiratory muscles become weaker.
- Rib cage more rigid.
- Alveoli thinner & less elastic which decreases exchange of gases
- Bronchioles lose elasticity.
- Changes in larynx lead to higher pitched & weaker voice.

- Decrease coughing reflex and decrease removal of mucus.
- Chronic diseases may decrease the efficiency of the respiratory system even more severely
- Dyspnea, breathing increases in rate, increases susceptibility to infections such as a cold or pneumonia.

Respiratory Care:

- Alternate activity with periods of rest.
- Proper body alignment & positioning.
- Sleep in semi-fowlers position: Use 2 or 3 pillows.
- Avoid polluted air and avoid air drafts.
- Breathe deeply & cough frequently.
- May need continuous oxygen therapy.

4- Nervous System Changes:-

- Blood flow to brain decreases & there is a progressive loss of brain cells interferes with:
 - Thinking
 - Interpreting
 - Reacting
 - Remembering
- Senses of taste, smell, vision, & hearing are diminished.
- Nerve endings less sensitive: Decreased ability to respond to pain and other stimuli.

5 - Changes in special senses:-

a- Changes in vision:-

- Problems with reading small print.
- Seeing objects at a distance.
- Decrease in peripheral vision.
- Decrease in night vision.& Increased sensitivity to glare.
- Cataracts and glaucoma.

b. Changes in hearing:-

- Hearing loss usually gradual.
- Person may speak louder than usual.
- Ask for words to be repeated.
- Not hear high sounds. May not hear well in crowded places.

b. Changes in smell and taste:

- Sense of smell is reduced with age because of decreases in the number of sensory cells in the nasal lining.
- Taste in the elderly is less acute because of the number of taste buds reduced.

d- Changes in touch:-

- Tactile sensation is reduced in the elderly.

6 – Digestive Changes:-

- Fewer digestive juices and enzymes produced.
- Muscle action becomes slower & peristalsis decreases.
- Dysphagia is frequent complaint due to:
 - Less saliva & Loss of teeth
 - Poor fitting dentures.
 - Slower digestion of food.
- Decrease peristalsis lead to
 - Increase flatulence (gas) & Constipation.
- Decrease sensation of taste
 - Poor appetite & Poor diet.

Digestive Care:

- Good oral hygiene.
- Repair or replace damaged teeth.
- Relaxed eating atmosphere.
- High-fiber high-protein foods with different tastes.
- Seasoning to improve taste.
- Increased fluid intake.

7- Urinary Changes:-

- Kidneys decrease in size & become less efficient.
- Bladder becomes less efficient as :
 - May not hold as much
 - May not empty completely
 - Incontinence.

Urinary Care:

- Increase fluid intake: Decrease before bedtime.
- Regular trips to bathroom.
- Easy to remove clothing.
- Use absorbent pads.

8 - Endocrine Changes:-

- Increased production of some hormones and decreased of others.
- Immune system less effective.
- Decrease thyroid gland activity.
- Alteration in pancreases function leads to decrease level of insulin and increase glucose level.

Endocrine Care

- Proper exercise.
- Adequate rest.
- Medical care for illness.
- Balanced diet. And healthy lifestyle.

9 - Reproductive System Changes:-

In female:- Decrease of estrogen / progesterone as :

- Thinning of vaginal wall
- Decrease vaginal secretions.
- Inflammation of vagina common.
 - Uterus sags downward (Uterine prolapse).
- Breasts sag when fat redistributed.

In male:- Decrease in Testosterone:

- Slow production of sperm.
- Response to sexual stimuli slower.
- Testes smaller less firm.
- Enlargement of prostate.

Reproductive Care:

- Understand physical and psychological sexual needs of the elderly
 - Give privacy to consenting elderly.
 - Ensure the older person has prostate examination annually.
 - Ensure frequent toileting.
 - Observe for signs of vaginitis.
 - Wear cotton closes (underwear) and frequently change it.

10 - Changes in Musculoskeletal system:-

- Atrophy in all muscles.
- Loss of muscle tone and strength.
- Joint were less mobile.
- Kyphosis seen.

Musculoskeletal care:-

- Encourage regular exercise.
- Avoid over straining or overusing muscles.
- Encourage good calcium intake.
- Provide safe environment.

2) Psychosocial Changes:-

- Some individual cope with psychosocial changes, and others experience extreme frustration and mental distress
- Health loss.
- Occupational and economic loss.
- Loss of friendships and loss of spouse.
- Fears of elder person lead to:
 - Death (loss of life)
 - Chronic illness and Loss of function & Pain.

Nursing actions related to Psychosocial Changes:-

1. Reality Orientation by the following action:

- Address person by name preferred.
- Make reference to day, time, and place.
- Use clocks, and calendars.
- Repeat instructions patiently, allow time for respond.

- Encourage conversations about familiar things or current events.
- Encourage use of TV, radio without over stimulating them.
- Keep familiar objects in view and avoid moving furniture.
- Encourage independence and self-help whenever possible.

THANK you